

does not let you control the compression settings, and you cannot create self-extracting archives. In order to achieve this, you need to install compression utilities such as WinZip from www.winzip.com, WinRAR from www.rarsoft.com, WinACE from www.winace.com, and PowerArchiver from www.powerarchiver.com. These software not only let you compress files and folders with a great degree of control over the compression ratio, some also let you choose the compression format, and let you create encrypted archives.

4. Image Viewing Software

Windows has image viewing and management software—namely, Windows Picture and Fax Viewer and MS Paint. But these only provide basic functionality, and you can choose from several other such software—most notably IrfanView (www.irfanview.com), ACDSee (www.acdsystems.com) and XnView (www.xnview.com). Many of these also have image management and editing capabilities.

5. Browsers

Internet Explorer 6 comes preinstalled with Windows XP, but there are other browsers such as Opera, Mozilla, and Firefox, which have features absent in IE—such as an RSS reader, tabbed browsing, and the ability to customise the browser by installing various plugins.

6. E-mail Clients

Windows XP comes with Outlook Express 6 inbuilt. Though OE is pretty OK, you might want to try out other e-mail clients such as Eudora (www.eudora.com), IncrediMail (www.incredimail.com) and Thunderbird (www.mozilla.com/thunderbird), which provide some additional features.